

Could
technology
allow me to
indefinitely
delay death?

For biological systems, death seems inevitable. Biological systems age and decay over time, and there is (so far as we know) no way to prevent this from happening.

Recent technological developments, though, have led many to pose the question of whether we might be able to indefinitely delay death, not by stopping or slowing the biological aging process, but by escaping our biological nature entirely.

We might attempt to do this by becoming, not biological systems, but synthetic artificially intelligent systems.

‘Artificial intelligence’ is a term for the ability of machines to perform tasks intelligently: for example, to strategize and to solve problems.

So defined, artificial intelligence is now all around us. There are plenty of examples of AI systems which are vastly better than humans at performing various tasks.

What does not yet exist is a **general** artificial intelligence:
an artificial intelligence capable of doing all or almost all
of the things that an ordinary adult human being can do.
No machine in existence (that we know of) has general
artificial intelligence.

Today we will discuss one way in which you might become a non-biological entity with general artificial intelligence — a pathway which may include choices which will be available to you in your lifetime.

Suppose that it is the year 2045. We have now developed silicon devices which replicate but improve upon the functioning of neurons or clusters of neurons. The silicon devices do just the same things as the neurons they replace, but more quickly and more efficiently.

We can further imagine that people who have surgeries of this kind enjoy improved cognitive functioning; they can solve problems much more quickly than in the past.

Other than that, though, the people notice no differences in their mental life before and after the surgery. After all, the silicon devices do just the same jobs as the neurons they replace, only faster.

It seems plausible that you could survive a series of surgeries of this kind. (It also seems that, if all your friends and coworkers were opting for surgeries of this kind, they would be extremely tempting.)

We can further imagine that a surgery exists which can supplement synthetic 'brains' with improved memory, so that more of one's memories could be reliably stored and retrieved.

Other than this improved memory, people who go for this surgery notice no further mental difference. It again appears as though you could survive this.

We could presumably also replace all of your organs and body parts with synthetic systems which were not subject to decay, and which worked much better than your current biological parts. Perhaps you would no longer have to sleep or eat (though you might have the option to do so). This might happen gradually, with individual body parts replaced with their improved synthetic counterparts.

It seems that you could survive having body parts replaced in this way.

At the end of this process, you would be a synthetic artificially intelligent system. And it seems that there would be nothing to stop your death being delayed indefinitely. After all, if some of your parts started to age poorly, you could just have them replaced.

Let's now talk about some examples (from the reading for today
from David Chalmers, 'The singularity').



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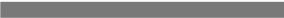
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It is instructive to think about how AI has progressed since Deep Blue.



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